

UCU 111: CRITICAL AND PROBLEM-SOLVING LECTURE 1 NOTES

1. Definition and meaning of Philosophy

Historical Origins of the Term “Philosophy”

The word *philosophy* has become central to intellectual history, symbolizing the pursuit of wisdom, truth, and meaning. But like many concepts, it has a beginning. The name itself was first associated with **Pythagoras of Samos (c. 570–495 BCE)**, the famous Greek thinker best remembered for his work in mathematics. While today he is widely linked to the “Pythagorean theorem,” his influence went far beyond mathematics. He founded a school of thought that combined science, religion, and ethics, and, most importantly, he is credited with introducing the very word *philosophy*—literally, “love of wisdom.”

Pythagoras lived in the **6th century BCE**, a period of intellectual awakening in ancient Greece known as the **Presocratic era**. This was the time when thinkers began moving away from mythological explanations of the world and toward rational inquiry (*logos*). Pythagoras was once asked whether he considered himself a *sophos*—a wise man. In ancient Greek culture, this term was used to describe individuals regarded as wise or possessing deep knowledge. Such men were often admired as sages. But Pythagoras declined to call himself wise. Instead, he responded that only the gods are truly wise. Human beings, no matter how learned, cannot claim possession of absolute wisdom. Instead, he described himself as a **philosophos**—a “lover of wisdom.” From this distinction arose the term **philosophia** —the love of wisdom.

Etymological definition

Philosophy is derived from the Greek term *Philosophia* which literally translates to the ‘Love of Wisdom.’ Etymologically, the term is derived from 2 Greek words: *Philo* and *Sophia*. Literally, *Philo* refers to Love and *Sophia* refers to wisdom. Thus, Philosophy is the love of wisdom. This implies that philosophy is a thoughtful and creative response to the exigencies of life

Popular/Common conception of Philosophy

The term philosophy has been used to mean a wide range of phenomena. For instance, the popular/common understanding of philosophy is that it is used to denote an attitude towards actions, activities. It can also be used to mean a people’s unique way of looking at the world (a people’s world view). This would refer to their fundamental beliefs and convictions. Philosophy can also be used to

UCU 111: CRITICAL AND PROBLEM-SOLVING LECTURE 1 NOTES

refer to a general outlook of what constitutes ideal society e.g. national philosophies such as Nyayoism, Ujamaa, e.t.c

Thus, all people and cultures can claim to have a philosophy to the extent that they have some ideas about; physical objects/world; man; meaning of life and death; good and bad; right/wrong; beauty and ugly etc. These idea or views may be a result of deliberate thinking or may be largely a result of convention

Technical sense of philosophy

Philosophy is defined as the rational inquiry into reality. This means that it is the systematic study of the world and our place in it and it entails a critical examination of reality characterized by rational inquiry that aims at the Truth for the sake of attaining wisdom.

2. Branches of Philosophy

Philosophy has four broad branches which include: Logic, Metaphysics, Epistemology, and Axiology.

Axiology

Axiology refers to the philosophical study of values. The study of values is divided into Ethics and Aesthetics.

Ethics is the study of moral values. This study consists in the systematic study of human conduct. It is also referred to as moral philosophy. Ethics studies how people ought to act, and the nature of good and evil acts. The term 'ethics' is derived from the Greek term '*ethos*' meaning 'custom' or 'habit.' Questions asked in ethics are such as, "How should people act," "What constitutes a right or wrong action," and many others. Ethics is the study of *morality and values*. It deals with questions such as:

- What is right and wrong?
- Should one always tell the truth?
- Is it justifiable to break the law for a good cause?

Aesthetics, on the other hand, is the study of beauty. It is concerned with the nature and appreciation of art, beauty, and good taste. The word Aesthetics is derived from the Greek term '*aisthetikos*' meaning 'of sense perception.' It asks:

UCU 111: CRITICAL AND PROBLEM-SOLVING LECTURE 1 NOTES

- What makes something beautiful?
- Is beauty universal or subjective?
- What is the role of art in human life?

For instance, why do people consider the Mona Lisa a masterpiece?

Epistemology

The term Epistemology is derived from the ancient Greek word *Episteme* which literally means Knowledge. Epistemology therefore refers to the study of knowledge. It seeks to establish the process of attaining knowledge, the nature of knowledge, and assesses the validity of this knowledge. It asks questions such as, “How do we know,” “How can we justify our knowledge claims,” “what are the sources of our knowledge” etc. It asks questions like:

- What is knowledge?
- How do we know what we claim to know?
- Can we be certain about anything?

Example: If you see smoke on a hill, do you *know* there is fire, or are you just assuming? Epistemology examines such reasoning.

Metaphysics

It is the branch of philosophy concerned with the study of existence. The term metaphysics is derived from 2 Greek words: *meta* and *physica*. Meta directly translates to ‘beyond’ while physica translates to ‘physical’. Literally metaphysics studies reality beyond the physical world. Metaphysics, therefore, studies the essence of things (that which makes things to be what they are). It deals with abstract reality and concepts that cannot be apprehended through the senses.

Metaphysics is the study of *reality and existence*. It asks questions such as:

- What is real?
- Do human beings have free will, or is everything determined?
- Is there a soul or spirit beyond the body?

Illustration: Think of a shadow. Metaphysics asks: *Is the shadow real, or is it only a reflection of something more real?*

Logic

UCU 111: CRITICAL AND PROBLEM-SOLVING LECTURE 1 NOTES

Logic is the study of the methods and principles used to distinguish between good and bad/bogus reasoning. It investigates and classifies the structure of statements and arguments and determines if they constitute right reasoning or not. Logic aims at securing the clarity and organization of our thought process so that our arguments have a consistency and accuracy. Questions asked in logic include: what is correct reasoning, what distinguishes a good argument from a bad one? Etc.

3. Characteristics of Philosophy

Philosophy transcends common sense view of world. It is characterized by the following;

a. Philosophy is CRITICAL

To say that philosophy is critical means that it does not accept ideas blindly. Instead, it examines, evaluates, and tests them carefully. Philosophers seek clarity, consistency, and truth by criticizing assumptions, traditions, and arguments. This does not mean being negative or destructive; rather, it means being analytical, cautious, and thoughtful before accepting any claim.

- Example: Instead of accepting traditions without thought, a philosopher asks, *why do we practice this custom?* Philosophy asks: Why do we believe what we believe? Are our assumptions justified?
- Example: People may assume that democracy is the best form of government. Philosophy asks: Why? What principles justify democracy? What are its limits?
 - Accepts only what is well grounded
 - Bases convictions, beliefs, and actions on well-reasoned grounds
 - Frees us from slogans, hypocrisy

b. Philosophy is INQUIRING

This means that philosophy is not content with accepting ideas, customs, or beliefs at face value. Instead, it constantly seeks to ask questions, probe deeper, and uncover underlying reasons. To say that philosophy is inquiring is to highlight its restless curiosity and its commitment to understanding truth through rational investigation.

- Open minded view of worlds
- 360% perceptibility of issues, not straitjacket

c. Philosophy is QUESTIONING

Philosophy is often described as the art of asking questions. Unlike other disciplines that may aim to provide fixed answers, philosophy thrives on questioning. It refuses to take assumptions, traditions, or even scientific claims for granted. Instead, it interrogates them, asking: Why do we

UCU 111: CRITICAL AND PROBLEM-SOLVING LECTURE 1 NOTES

believe this? What does it mean? Is it really true? This spirit of questioning is one of philosophy's defining features.

To say that philosophy is questioning means that it constantly challenges assumptions and seeks clarification. Questioning is not about being skeptical for the sake of skepticism; it is about searching for truth and deeper meaning. For example: Most people assume happiness comes from wealth. A philosopher asks: What is happiness? Can money truly make us happy? Is happiness the same as pleasure?

Philosophers ask whether customs, laws, or religious practices are justified. Philosophical questioning aims to clarify vague or confusing ideas. Philosophical questioning often takes place through conversation, where questions lead to reflection and debate.

d. Philosophy is REFLECTIVE

Philosophy involves deep thinking and self-examination. It requires one to step back and look at life with fresh eyes. Reflection means turning inward, examining one's own beliefs, values, and assumptions. It is a process of careful thought that goes beyond immediate reactions or opinions.

Reflection involves deep thinking about life and experience. Instead of simply reacting to events, philosophers step back to consider their meaning and implications. It is like holding up a mirror to one's thoughts and examining them critically.

e. Philosophy is RATIONAL

Philosophy depends on reasoning, not mere feelings or authority. It relies on reason and logical argument rather than on superstition, emotion, or blind faith. To be rational is to think clearly, consistently, and with evidence.

This is why philosophy has been called the "mother of sciences"—because its rational methods laid the foundation for systematic knowledge. Rationality involves using logic, reasoning, and critical analysis to reach conclusions. Philosophers argue for their positions with evidence and reasoning rather than authority or tradition.

For example: Instead of saying, "This is true because my teacher says so or because it has always been accepted in our society," philosophy asks: *What are the reasons and evidence for this claim?*

4. Scope of Philosophy

The scope of philosophy refers to the range of issues and areas it tries to address. These include but not limited to:

1. Reality – What exists? Is there a God? Is there life after death? Where did the world come from? etc.
2. Knowledge – What can we know? How do we know it? Can human beings ever know the truth?
3. Values – What is right and wrong? What is beauty? What makes life meaningful?
4. Society – What is justice? What is the best form of government?
5. Mind and Self – Who am I? What is consciousness?

UCU 111: CRITICAL AND PROBLEM-SOLVING LECTURE 1 NOTES

In short, philosophy investigates the fundamental questions of life that every human being, at one point or another, has asked.

5. Relevance of Philosophy

Inculcating Autonomy of Thought

Philosophy nurtures the ability to think independently, empowering individuals to form their own opinions rather than blindly following authority or popular views. In Kenya, this is especially relevant in the political arena where voter choices are often influenced by ethnic affiliations. Philosophical thinking encourages citizens to vote based on policies and principles rather than tribal loyalties. For example, during election campaigns, autonomous thinkers evaluate manifestos critically instead of simply following ethnic endorsements.

Questioning Traditions

While traditions preserve culture, not all traditions promote human dignity. Philosophy teaches us to examine traditions critically and reform those that are harmful. In Kenya, practices such as female genital mutilation (FGM) and early marriage persist in some communities. Philosophical reflection enables society to question whether these traditions uphold human rights or perpetuate injustice. As a result, many campaigns against FGM in Kenya have succeeded by using ethical arguments grounded in human dignity and well-being.

Evaluating and Analyzing Belief Systems

Kenyan society is deeply religious and culturally diverse. Philosophy helps people evaluate belief systems critically, distinguishing between genuine spiritual guidance and exploitative practices. For instance, the rise of prosperity gospel churches has raised questions about exploitation of vulnerable members through promises of miracles in exchange for money. Philosophy provides a framework for distinguishing authentic faith from manipulation. Similarly, it helps analyze political ideologies like nationalism or Pan-Africanism, evaluating their impact on unity and development.

Examining Assumptions

Many social and political conflicts in Kenya arise from unexamined assumptions. For example, the assumption that certain ethnic groups are better suited for leadership fuels division and

UCU 111: CRITICAL AND PROBLEM-SOLVING LECTURE 1 NOTES

weakens democracy. Philosophy challenges such assumptions by asking whether they are logically valid or morally justifiable. Another example is the assumption that economic growth automatically improves people's lives. Philosophical reflection reveals that without equity and justice, growth alone cannot guarantee well-being.

Eliminating Rote Learning

The Kenyan education system has often been criticized for emphasizing memorization over critical thinking. Philosophy combats rote learning by encouraging learners to reason, analyze, and reflect. The ongoing Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC) reforms aim to shift from memorization to skill-based learning, which aligns with the philosophical spirit of deep understanding. For example, instead of merely memorizing the provisions of the 2010 Constitution, students can be taught to debate its meaning, relevance, and implications for governance.

Inculcating Ethics

Philosophy provides ethical frameworks necessary for guiding behavior in personal and public life. In Kenya, corruption remains a major challenge despite numerous laws. What is missing is the ethical consciousness that philosophy cultivates. By reflecting on ethical principles such as justice, honesty, and responsibility, citizens and leaders can make decisions that prioritize the common good. For example, ethical reasoning helps question why public resources meant for healthcare should never be diverted to private gain. It also guides debates on moral issues such as LGBTQ+ rights and gender equality.

Adapting to Changes in the World

Kenya is part of a globalized world, and rapid changes in technology, culture, and economics require adaptability. Philosophy equips individuals with critical tools to navigate these changes without losing identity. For instance, Kenya's youth are exposed to global media influences that sometimes conflict with traditional values. A philosophical outlook enables them to embrace progressive ideas while critically evaluating those that may undermine social cohesion. Similarly, in dealing with climate change, philosophy helps balance development goals with environmental sustainability.

UCU 111: CRITICAL AND PROBLEM-SOLVING LECTURE 1 NOTES

Integrating Technology and New Ideas

Kenya is renowned for technological innovations such as M-Pesa, which transformed financial services globally. However, the introduction of new technologies often raises ethical and cultural concerns. Philosophy enables society to evaluate technology's impact critically instead of rejecting it merely because it is unfamiliar. For example, debates about digital lending platforms in Kenya highlight concerns over privacy, exploitation, and debt. A philosophical approach helps balance innovation with ethical safeguards, ensuring that technology serves human welfare while avoiding harm.